Everyday AI: Work & email

12 step-by-step guides for real, everyday tasks

Work & email

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Before you start — what this is, honestly

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Work & email

Automate Email Drafts with AI for Faster Inbox Management

7 steps · Read online

By the end of this guide, you'll have a clever system that writes draft replies for you, helping you spend mere seconds instead of minutes on each routine inbox message. This is perfect for anyone who feels their email is a time-sink, whether you're handling personal messages, customer queries, or internal staff notes. It can draft the email, but remember, it can't send it for you – you'll always have the final say!

Before you start

- **A device with a web browser:** You'll be using web-based tools, so a computer or tablet is ideal.
- **A working email account:** You'll need an account like Gmail, Outlook, or any web-based service.
- **A free AI account with API access:** You'll need access to an AI service that offers an **API key**. Think of this like a special password that lets other programs connect to the AI securely. Examples include OpenAI's platform (for ChatGPT models), Claude, or Google's AI Studio. While signing up for these platforms is often free, using the API incurs small costs, typically a few cents per request. A "free chat account" alone usually isn't enough, as you need developer access.
- **A free account with a no-code automation service:** Tools like Zapier, Make, or IFTTT allow different apps to "talk" to each other without writing any computer code. We'll use Zapier as our example. Be aware that creating multi-step workflows, like the one in this guide, often requires a paid plan after a trial period or for higher usage, even if initial sign-up is free.
- **Time commitment:** This setup will take approximately 20-30 minutes to complete the initial steps and then a few minutes for testing and refining.

Step 1 — Sign up and find your AI API key

Your first step is to get an **API key** from your chosen AI tool. An API key is a unique string of characters that acts like a secret token, allowing external services (like our automation tool) to communicate with the AI securely without you manually logging in each time.

Open your web browser and go to the developer platform for your chosen AI (e.g., platform.openai.com for OpenAI, console.anthropic.com for Claude). After you log in or sign up, you'll typically see a dashboard. Look for a menu item like "API Keys," "Settings," or "Developer" in the left sidebar or under your profile picture. When you click it, you should see an option to "Create new secret key" or "Generate API key." Click this button. A new, long string of letters and numbers will appear on your screen. Immediately copy this key and paste it into a secure location, like a password manager or a temporary text document. You usually won't be able to see it again after you close the window, so don't lose it!

You'll know it worked when you have a long, unique string of characters (your API key) copied and safely stored, confirming your AI platform is ready for connection.

Example (for OpenAI): Go to `platform.openai.com/api-keys`. If you're signed in, you'll see your API Keys page. Click the "+ Create new secret key" button. A new key will pop up. Click the green 'copy' icon next to it and save it.

Step 2 — Create a new email filter

Next, you'll set up a **filter** in your email account. A filter is like a personal email sorter that automatically watches for incoming messages that match specific criteria (like words in the subject line or sender address) and then performs an action. For this guide, we'll create a filter that identifies emails that need an AI-generated draft reply.

Open your email account in a web browser and navigate to your email settings. Look for options labeled "Filters," "Rules," or "Manage rules." For Gmail users, click the gear icon ( ) in the top-right corner, then select "See all settings," and finally, click on "Filters and Blocked Addresses." Here, you'll see a button like "Create a new filter." Click it, and a form will appear with fields such as "From," "To," and "Subject." In the "Subject" field, type a distinct word or phrase that will signal to your system that this email needs an AI-drafted reply, such as "AI Draft Request" (without the quotes). Leave all other fields blank for now. Then, click "Create filter" or "Continue." A warning might appear about not having actions selected; that's fine for now, just confirm.

You'll know it worked when you see your newly created filter listed among your email rules, indicating it's ready to watch for matching emails.

Example (for Gmail): Click > "See all settings" > "Filters and Blocked Addresses" > "Create a new filter." In the "Subject" field, type `AI Draft Request`. Click "Create filter" and confirm any warnings.

Step 3 — Craft your AI prompt template

Now it's time to write the instructions you'll give to your AI, known as a **prompt**. This is like telling a human assistant exactly how to draft a reply for you. A **prompt template** includes special placeholders, which are like empty boxes where the AI will insert specific information from the email it needs to reply to.

Open a simple text editor (like Notepad, Google Docs, or Apple Notes) where you can easily copy and paste text. Think about the kind of replies you want: friendly, formal, concise, or detailed. A good prompt is clear and tells the AI its role and what to do. For instance, you'll instruct it to acknowledge the sender and suggest a few steps. The crucial placeholder you'll use is `{{email_body}}` – this tells the AI exactly where to insert the actual content of the email it's replying to.

You'll know it worked when you have a complete, clear instruction, including `{{email_body}}`, saved in your text editor, which you feel confident will produce the kind of reply you're after.

Example prompt:

```
You are a professional customer service assistant. Write a polite, concise draft email reply in US English. Acknowledge the sender's message
```

```
Email content to reply to:
{{email_body}}
```

Step 4 — Set up the Zapier trigger

This step brings your email and AI together using an **automation service** like Zapier. A "Zap" in Zapier is an automated workflow that starts with a **Trigger** (an event that kicks things off) and then performs one or more **Actions**. Here, our trigger will be a new email matching the filter you set up in Step 2.

Log in to your Zapier account and click the "Create Zap" button. You'll see a screen to choose your Trigger. Search for and select your email provider (e.g., "Gmail"). For the "Event" field, choose "New Email Matching Search." You'll then be asked to connect your email account if you haven't already. In the "Search String" field, enter the exact phrase you used in your email filter in Step 2 (e.g., `subject:"AI Draft Request"`). Follow the prompts to test this trigger. Zapier will try to find a recent email that matches your criteria to ensure it's working.

You'll know it worked when Zapier successfully tests your trigger, indicating it can find new emails that match your filter criteria.

Example (for Zapier):

1. On the "Trigger" screen, search for and select "Gmail."
2. For "Event," choose "New Email Matching Search."
3. For "Search String," type `subject:"AI Draft Request"` (including the quotes).
4. Click "Continue" and follow the steps to connect your Gmail and test the trigger.

Step 5 — Add the AI action in Zapier

Now that Zapier can detect new emails, you need to tell it to send that email's content to your AI to generate a reply. This is the first **Action** step in your Zap.

After successfully setting up your trigger, click the "Add a step" button (often a plus sign or "Action" button). Search for and select your chosen AI tool (e.g., "OpenAI" or "Claude"). For the "Event" field, you'll typically choose an action like "Send Prompt" or "Generate Content." You'll be prompted to connect your AI account; this is where you'll paste your **API key** from Step 1. In the "Prompt" field, paste your entire prompt template from Step 3. Crucially, replace the `{{email_body}}` placeholder by clicking into the prompt field and selecting the "Body" or "Plain Body" option from your previous email trigger step. This tells the AI to use the actual email content. You might also be asked to select a model (e.g., "gpt-3.5-turbo"). Test this action to see if the AI generates a sample response.

You'll know it worked when the test of this action shows a generated text response from the AI, containing a draft reply based on a sample email.

Example (for Zapier):

1. On the "Action" screen, search for and select "OpenAI."
2. For "Event," choose "Send Prompt."
3. Connect your OpenAI account by pasting your API Key from Step 1.
4. In the "Prompt" field, paste your full template. Click into the prompt field where `{{email_body}}` was, and from the dropdown that appears, select "Body Plain" (or similar) from the Gmail trigger step.
5. Test the action.

Step 6 — Create the email draft in Zapier

The final step in your Zap is to take the AI's generated response and save it as a new draft email in your inbox. This is the second **Action** step.

After successfully testing your AI action, click "Add a step" again. Search for and select your email provider (e.g., "Gmail"). For the "Event" field, choose "Create Draft." You'll connect your email account again if needed. In the fields that appear, you'll map the AI's response to the body of your new draft. For "To," you can select the "From Email" from your initial trigger. For "Subject," you might write "RE: " and then select the

"Subject" from your trigger. For the "Body" field, select the output from your AI action step (e.g., "Choice 1 Text" or "Content"). You can also choose to include the original email if you like. Finally, activate your Zap by turning it "On."

You'll know it worked when Zapier successfully tests this action by creating a new draft in your email account, containing the AI's response.

Example (for Zapier):

1. On the "Action" screen, search for and select "Gmail."
2. For "Event," choose "Create Draft."
3. Connect your Gmail account.
4. For "To," select "From Email" from your initial Gmail trigger step.
5. For "Subject," type `RE:` and then select "Subject" from the initial Gmail trigger step.
6. For "Body," select "Choice 1 Text" from your OpenAI action step.
7. Test the action and then turn your Zap "On."

Step 7 — Test your automation and refine

The hard work is done – now for the fun part: testing! You want to make sure your AI assistant is drafting exactly what you expect.

Open your email client and send yourself a brand new email that perfectly matches the filter criteria you set in Step 2 (e.g., using "AI Draft Request" in the subject line). Go to your "Drafts" folder in your email account. After a minute or two, you should see a newly generated draft reply there. Read it carefully. Is the tone right? Is it too long or too short? Does it make sense? If the draft isn't quite right, go back to Zapier, edit your AI action step, and tweak the wording of your prompt template. Change things like "short, professional" to "brief, friendly and informal," or adjust the word count. Then, send yourself another test email and check the new draft. You can repeat this process as many times as needed to get the perfect reply. Always remember to review each draft before hitting send – the AI is there to assist, not replace your judgement.

You'll know it worked when you consistently receive AI-generated drafts in your drafts folder that you would feel comfortable sending, maybe with just a minor edit or two, matching your desired tone and content.

Example: After a test run, you find the draft is a bit too formal. Go back to Zapier, edit your OpenAI action, and change the prompt line "Write a polite, concise draft email reply" to "Write a friendly, informal, and very brief draft email reply." Then, send another test email to yourself.

Common mistakes

- **Not protecting your API key:** This key grants access to your AI account, potentially incurring costs. Store it securely in a password manager and never share it publicly. If it's compromised, immediately generate a new one and delete the old one in your AI tool's settings.
- **Setting the email filter too broadly:** If your email filter (from Step 2) is too general (like "contains 'the'"), you'll get draft replies for newsletters, spam, and personal messages you don't need help with. Make your filter specific to recurring, predictable email types (e.g., `subject:"AI Draft Request"` or `from:"[specific sender email]"`).
- **Skipping the final review step:** While AI is powerful, it can occasionally misinterpret tone, insert invented facts, or miss crucial nuances. Always give the draft a quick read before hitting send to avoid embarrassing mistakes or misleading your recipient.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** You can breeze through routine messages like "Can you share the file?" or "Thanks for the update" with a ready-made reply, freeing up minutes for the things you enjoy, like hobbies or spending time with loved ones.
- **For your business or work:** Customer-service teams can handle frequent, simple queries faster, keeping response times low and clients happy without needing to hire extra staff for basic tasks. It can also help you quickly respond to internal requests, keeping projects moving smoothly.
- **If you're just getting started:** The easiest first move is to set a filter for a single, very common phrase you receive (e.g., "thank you for your email") and let the AI draft a very short, one-sentence acknowledgment. You'll see the time saved instantly.

Try it now

In the next two minutes, open your email settings, create a new filter, and set it to watch for the subject word "test" (without quotes). For now, set the action to "Mark as important" and "Apply the filter to matching conversations." This tiny change will already start grouping similar emails, making it easier to apply the AI draft process later. Happy automating!

How to Get Quick Summaries from Long Documents with Claude

7 steps · Read online

Ever feel swamped by lengthy reports, articles, or complex documents? This guide will show you how to use Claude, an **AI (Artificial Intelligence)**, which is like a very smart computer program designed to think and learn, to quickly get the main points from almost any text. By the end, you'll be able to upload a document and ask Claude to summarize it for you, giving you the essential information you need in a flash.

Before you start

- You'll need a free Claude account (or a paid plan if you prefer). This will give you access to Claude's website.
- Access to the Claude website through your computer's web browser.
- A digital document you want to summarize, such as a PDF or a plain text file. Note that Claude has limits on the file size and length it can process, but free plans are usually sufficient for most common documents.
- This whole process should take you about 5-7 minutes.

Step 1 — Access Claude's Website

Your first step is to open your web browser and navigate to the Claude website. Think of Claude as a powerful **Large Language Model (LLM)**, which is like the highly intelligent engine behind an AI, specifically designed to understand and generate human language. You'll usually see a clean, welcoming chat interface where you can begin interacting with the AI.

You'll know it worked when you see a main chat area, often with a text box at the bottom ready for you to type in.

Step 2 — Start a New Conversation

To ensure you're starting fresh, it's a good idea to begin a new conversation with Claude. Look for a "New Chat" button, which is commonly found on the left-hand side of the screen or near the top. Clicking this will give you a clean slate, meaning Claude won't carry over any previous topics or instructions from old chats, so your summary request will be clear.

If it looks different on your screen, don't worry! Apps change often. You might see a small plus (+) icon, or a menu option like "Start new conversation." Simply click whatever seems to open a fresh chat.

You'll know it worked when the main chat window is clear, with no previous messages, and the message box at the bottom is empty, waiting for your input.

Step 3 — Upload Your Document

Now it's time to get your document into Claude. Look for a paperclip icon, usually found near the message box where you type. This icon is universally used for attachments. Clicking it will open your computer's file explorer, allowing you to browse and select the PDF or text file you wish to summarize. Claude can handle various formats, but PDFs and plain text are generally the most reliable for summarisation. Remember, very large files might not upload on a free plan, as Claude, like all AIs, has a **context window** – this is like the AI's short-term memory, limiting how much text it can 'remember' at once.

If you don't see a paperclip, look for an "Attach file" text link or a similar icon that suggests adding a file.

You'll know it worked when the name of your uploaded document appears in the message box, usually next to your cursor, indicating it's ready to be sent.

Step 4 — Craft Your Summary Request

With your document attached, it's time to tell Claude what you want. This instruction is called a **prompt**, which is simply the command you give to the AI. In the message box, type out a clear request for a summary. Being specific helps Claude understand exactly what you're looking for, rather than just giving a generic overview. For instance, you could ask for specific details or a summary tailored to a particular audience.

If your message box is hard to find, it's usually a long, horizontal bar at the very bottom of the chat window.

You'll know it worked when your complete summary request appears in the message box, ready to be sent to Claude. 💬 Example: "Please summarize this document for me, highlighting the main points and key takeaways relevant to small businesses."

Step 5 — Send Your Request

Once your document is attached and your summary request is typed, the next step is to send it to Claude. Look for a "Send" button or a paper plane icon, usually located at the right end of the message box. Clicking this will submit both your document and your prompt to the AI. Claude will then begin processing the information, reading through your document and generating a summary based on your instructions. This process usually happens quite quickly.

If the button looks different, it might be an arrow or just the word "Send". Just click the button that looks like it will submit your message.

You'll know it worked when your message disappears from the box, and Claude's response starts appearing in the main chat window, beginning with your requested summary.

Step 6 — Review and Refine the Summary

After Claude generates the summary, take a moment to read through it. AI responses are usually very helpful, but sometimes they might not hit every single point you need, or you might want more detail on a specific section. This is where you can interact further. If you need more information or a different perspective, just type another prompt in the message box, referring back to the document or the summary Claude just gave you. For example, you could ask Claude to elaborate on a particular section or rephrase the summary for a different audience.

If the answer isn't quite what you expected, don't worry, that's normal with AIs. Just try rephrasing your question or adding more specific details in your next prompt.

You'll know it worked when you've either received a summary that fully meets your needs or have asked follow-up questions that yield the specific additional information you were looking for. 💬 Example: "Can you list the top three challenges mentioned in the document and suggest potential solutions?"

Step 7 — Save or Copy Your Summary

Once you're happy with Claude's summary, you'll likely want to save or copy it for your own use. You can typically highlight the text of Claude's response using your mouse, then right-click and select "Copy." You can then paste this summary into a document, email, or wherever you need it. Some AI tools also offer specific "Copy" buttons next to their responses or even export options, though these vary.

If you don't see a direct "copy" button, highlighting the text and using your computer's standard copy (Ctrl+C on Windows, Command+C on Mac) and paste (Ctrl+V or Command+V) functions will always work.

You'll know it worked when you've successfully pasted the summary into another application or saved it to a file, making it ready for your tasks.

Common mistakes

- **Uploading unsupported files or files that are too large:** Claude works best with common document types like PDFs, Word documents, and text files. If you try to upload an image or a video, or a document that's many hundreds of pages long, it might not work.
  - **The fix:** Convert your file to a supported format like PDF or plain text. If it's very long, you might need to split it into smaller sections or use a paid plan with a larger context window.
- **Vague summary requests:** Just saying "Summarize this" might give you a general overview, but it might not be what you actually need. Claude is good, but it can't read your mind!
  - **The fix:** Be specific! Ask for "three key takeaways," "a summary for someone who knows nothing about this topic," or "the pros and cons of this proposal." The more detail you give in your **prompt**, the better the result.
- **Not verifying critical information:** While Claude is powerful, it's an AI and can sometimes **hallucinate**, which is when an AI confidently presents false or inaccurate information as if it were true. It generates text based on patterns, not absolute truth.
  - **The fix:** Always cross-check any critical facts, figures, or sensitive information from the summary with the original document or another reliable source, especially if you plan to use the summary for important decisions. Claude can draft an excellent summary, but it can't verify the truthfulness of *every single detail* for you, especially in complex or niche topics.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Imagine quickly understanding the long terms and conditions for a new app, getting the gist of a lengthy news article, or grasping the main points of a new recipe or instruction manual without reading every single word. Claude can save you precious time.
- **For your business or work:** This skill is invaluable for professionals. You can rapidly review lengthy reports, condense meeting minutes, extract key findings from research papers, or quickly understand client briefs, allowing you to focus on decision-making rather than sifting through pages of text.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick a news article you're interested in online. Copy the main text, paste it into a new Claude conversation, and ask, "Summarize this for me in three sentences." It's a quick, easy way to get a feel for how it works!

Try it now

Find a short PDF document (perhaps a product manual or a short article) or copy-paste the text from a recent online news story into Claude, and then ask it to "Give me the top three main points from this text." See how quickly you can get to the core information!

Turn Messy Notes into a Polite Meeting Agenda in Five Minutes

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Paste your messy email thread or bullet list into any AI assistant with a clear instruction about timing, owners, and tone, then iterate. You'll get a polite, structured agenda in under five minutes — though you'll still need to send the invites yourself.

A 30-minute meeting with seven bullet points, three owners, and zero structure usually ends with 20 minutes wasted on "wait, who's covering that?" — and another 10 on a follow-up email nobody reads. This guide shows how to feed that mess into any AI assistant and walk out with a timed, owner-clear agenda you can actually send. It's written for people who already use AI for everyday tasks and want one more workflow that saves real time at work.

Before you start

- An account on any AI assistant you already use — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, Le Chat, or DeepSeek all handle this pattern. No new signup needed.
- The messy source material within reach: an email thread to copy from, a notes app with bullet points, or a transcribed voice memo.
- About five minutes once you've done it once; a little longer the first time as you build your reusable template.

Step 1 — Gather the messy material in one place

Open your AI assistant in a browser or app and start a fresh chat. Paste your raw material — the email thread, the bullet list, the voice-note transcript — straight into the message box, and add two short sentences of context before you hit send: what the meeting is for, how long it is, and who's coming. You're not asking for the agenda yet; you're staging the inputs.

Example: "Below is the email thread about our Q3 launch. Goal: 30-minute sync to unblock the design freeze. Attendees: Maria, John, Sarah."

You'll see your pasted text sitting in the input area, with the send button below it. After you send, the assistant confirms receipt and begins working. If your assistant has a "Projects" or "custom instructions" feature, you can save the context sentence there for next time — but a plain chat works fine without it.

You'll know it worked when the assistant's first reply acknowledges the inputs you provided and starts producing structured output rather than asking what you meant.

Step 2 — Ask for a first draft with explicit structure

Send a follow-up instruction in the same chat telling the assistant how to shape the draft: numbered topics, a duration in minutes next to each, a named owner per topic, a polite opener, and a small buffer between items. The clearer your structure request, the less you'll need to fix later.

Example: "Now produce the draft. Use a polite opener, list each topic with a duration in minutes and a single owner, leave a 2-minute buffer between topics, and end with a one-line confirmation request."

You'll see a numbered agenda appear, with minutes and names attached to each line. If your assistant formats the response as a table by default — some do — reply with "please rewrite as a numbered list with bold topic names" and the next version arrives in the shape you wanted.

You'll know it worked when your chaotic items are reordered into clear blocks with names and minutes, and you can read the whole meeting in one glance.

Step 3 — Calibrate the politeness

Reply in the same chat asking for tone adjustments. The first draft is almost never the right tone — it usually sounds either too stiff ("Please find below the agenda…") or too casual for a workplace you share with senior people. Tell the assistant which direction to move.

Example: "The opener feels stiff. Loosen it. Our team uses first names and avoids phrases like 'circling back'. Keep the same structure and timings."

You'll see a revised version where the wording changes but the structure stays. If the assistant doesn't pick up your tone signal, paste one sentence of how you'd actually open the meeting and ask it to match that register — that's the fastest shortcut to a natural voice.

You'll know it worked when the opener reads like something you'd say out loud without wincing.

Step 4 — Lock down the owners and timing

Send another short instruction asking the assistant to verify two things: each topic has exactly one named owner, and the minutes add up to the meeting length. This is where most agendas quietly fall apart — two topics assigned to the same person back-to-back, or a 45-minute agenda for a

30-minute slot.

💬 Example: "Confirm each topic has exactly one owner. Add up the minutes and show the total at the end. If anything overflows, suggest what to cut."

You'll see a revised agenda where totals match and names sit beside each item. If the assistant doesn't add a "Total: X minutes" footer, ask for one — it's the simplest way to verify the math yourself before you copy anything out.

You'll know it worked when the total at the bottom equals your available time, and no item is missing a name.

Step 5 — Add a closing line with next steps

Ask the assistant to add a short "Next steps" block at the bottom: who sends the calendar invite, who brings what (slides, doc, numbers), and when the follow-up happens. This is the part most agendas skip, and it's the part that decides whether the meeting actually moves anything.

💬 Example: "Add a 'Next steps' block at the end: Maria sends the calendar invite by tomorrow morning; John brings the latest design mockup; follow-up sync the following Monday."

You'll see a new block appear below the agenda. If your team uses a specific tool — Notion, Google Docs, Slack — name it in your prompt and the assistant will adjust the closing line to fit that workflow.

You'll know it worked when each person at the meeting knows exactly what to do before it starts and after it ends.

Step 6 — Copy the result into your real-world tool

Select the final agenda in the chat and paste it into the place your team will actually see it — an email draft, a shared doc, a calendar description, or your meeting software. This step is small but it matters: the moment the agenda lives outside the chat, you can edit it, share it, and update it without re-asking the AI.

If your assistant offers a "copy" or "export" button, use it; otherwise highlight the text and use your system copy shortcut. The text lands in the new tool with light formatting shifts depending on the destination — that's normal.

You'll know it worked when the agenda sits in the same place your team already works, and you didn't need to retype a single bullet.

Step 7 — Save your prompt as a reusable template

Highlight the full chat — your original messy input, the structure request, the tone instructions, the owners-and-timing check, the closing block — and save it as a reusable template. A plain text file in your notes app works. If your assistant supports saved prompts or custom instructions, use that instead so the template loads automatically.

💬 Example: a doc titled "Agenda from messy notes" with three labeled blocks: [PASTE INPUT], [STRUCTURE REQUEST], [TONE NOTES].

Next time you have a chaotic thread, you paste the template, swap in the new content, and skip the prompt-writing step. The first time costs you ten minutes; every meeting after that costs you one.

You'll know it worked when the next agenda takes you under a minute to draft.

Common mistakes

- **Treating the first draft as final.** The first reply is a sketch. Always run one tone-and-owners pass — usually two — before you copy anything out.
- **Owners stay vague ("the team", "marketing").** Vague owners mean nobody follows up. One named person per topic, every time, no exceptions.
- **Forgetting the AI can't send the invite.** Once you copy the agenda out, the chat ends and the tool stops helping. You still need to send the calendar invite, share the doc, and chase the owners yourself.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** The same pattern tidies up a 10-minute prep before a school meeting, a volunteer group call, or a family planning session — paste the chaos, ask for structure, lock in who does what.
- **For your business or work:** Every recurring meeting — weekly stand-up, monthly review, project sync — gets a polished, owner-clear agenda in minutes instead of 30 minutes of wrestling with bullet points.
- **If you want to go further:** Try the same input-to-structure pattern on other meeting artefacts: a recap email after the meeting, a project kickoff brief from a Slack thread, or a status report from scattered updates. The skill is the same — stage the messy input, request the shape you want, iterate on tone and owners.

Try it now

Open any AI assistant, paste your messiest recent email thread, and send this single line: "Turn this into a 30-minute agenda with one named owner per topic and a polite opener." Watch what comes back — that's your starting point for the iteration loop above.

Build a simple review form for your small business with GitHub Copilot

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** GitHub Copilot can build a "Leave a review" form (HTML, CSS, and JavaScript) in about 15 minutes inside a free browser editor. You'll still need a free service like Formspree to actually deliver reviews to your inbox — plain HTML alone can't save data on its own.

If you run a small shop, café, or local service, you already know how much a few honest reviews help. You probably also know that hiring a developer to build a "Leave a review" form can cost more than you'd like to spend. This guide walks you through having GitHub Copilot write that form for you — and explains, in plain words, what it can do and what it can't.

Before you start

- A free GitHub account (sign up at github.com — all you need is an email).
- A modern browser like Chrome, Edge, or Firefox.
- About 15–20 minutes of quiet time.
- A short list of 3 fields you want on your form (most review forms just need: customer name, star rating, and a comment box).
- Heads-up: GitHub Copilot offers both free and paid plans — check GitHub's pricing page for the current options before you start.

Step 1 — Open a free Codespace (your code editor in the cloud)

Sign in to github.com, then head to github.com/codespaces and click the green **"New codespace"** button. Pick the **"Blank"** template and choose a small machine (2-core is plenty for a tiny form). A new tab opens with a full code editor — it looks a lot like VS Code, but it runs in your browser. Wait about 30 seconds for it to load. If the Codespaces button is hard to find, create a new empty repository first (click the **"+"** in the top-right, then **"New repository"**), then click the green **"Code"** button and pick the **"Codespaces"** tab. You'll know it worked when you see a dark editor screen with a file panel on the left and a small terminal panel at the bottom. 💬 Example: name your repository `review-form` so it's easy to find later.

Step 2 — Make a new file for your form

In the left-hand file panel, look for an icon that looks like a piece of paper with a folded corner — that's the **"New File"** button. Click it, type `index.html` as the file name, and press Enter. A blank white editor opens in the middle of the screen — that's where your form will live. If that button isn't where you expect, right-click anywhere in the empty file panel and choose **"New File"** from the menu that pops up. You'll know it worked when `index.html` shows up in the left panel and the editor in the middle is empty, with a line number 1 on the left edge.

Step 3 — Ask Copilot to build the form for you

Look for the **Copilot Chat icon** in the left sidebar — it usually looks like a small speech bubble or a sparkle ✨. Click it. A chat panel slides open on the right. In the box at the bottom, type your request in plain English. Be specific about the three fields you want. If you don't see a chat icon, try the keyboard shortcut **Ctrl + Shift + I** on Windows/Linux, or **Cmd + Shift + I** on Mac — that opens the same chat panel. 💬 Example: *"Write a clean HTML form for a small bakery called 'Sunrise Sourdough'. Ask for the customer's name, a star rating from 1 to 5, and a comment box. Include a nice 'Submit review' button."* You'll know it worked when Copilot replies with a block of HTML code in the chat, and a small **"Apply"** or **"Copy"** button sits next to it.

Step 4 — Paste the code into your file and save it

Click into your empty `index.html` file so the cursor is inside it. Then press **Ctrl + V** (or **Cmd + V** on Mac) to paste the code from the chat. If a small popup asks you to confirm, click **"Accept"**. Save the file with **Ctrl + S** (or **Cmd + S**). If your keyboard shortcuts don't match, look at the top menu bar for **File → Save** instead — every code editor has that. You'll know it worked when the file no longer has a dot next to its name in the left panel (dots mean unsaved changes). The tab at the top should now read `index.html` with no little asterisk. 💬 Example: if Copilot's reply was a chat message instead of a code block, copy it from the chat, then paste it into the file the same way.

Step 5 — Ask Copilot to style it

Now make it look nice. Go back to the Copilot Chat panel and type a follow-up like the example below. Copilot replies with CSS — the part that controls colors, spacing, and fonts. Click the **"Apply"** button if it appears; otherwise click **"Copy"** and paste the CSS at the top of your file just after the opening `<head>` tag. If "Apply" isn't visible, look for a small **"Insert at cursor"** link near the code block — most editors offer one. You'll know it worked when your file has new lines starting with `<style>` and ending with `</style>`, and the code inside has words like `color`, `padding`, or `border-radius`. 💬 Example: *"Now add CSS that makes the form look warm and friendly — soft cream background, rounded corners, and a brown 'Submit' button. Keep it simple."*

Step 6 — Make it actually deliver the review to you

A form sitting on a page by itself can collect information in the browser, but it can't email you the results without a small extra step. The honest thing here: Copilot can write the front-end (what visitors see), but to receive reviews in your inbox you'll need a free form service. **Formspree** has a free tier that works well — sign up, get a form endpoint (a long web address), then ask Copilot to point your form at it. In the chat, type something like the example. Copilot will rewrite the `<form>` tag so the data goes to Formspree, which then forwards it to your email. If Formspree's setup looks confusing, ask Copilot instead: *"Change the submit button so it opens the user's email app with the review already filled in."* That quick shortcut uses a `mailto:` link and works without any third-party service. You'll know it worked when you click **Submit** in the preview and either (a) Formspree shows a thank-you page, or (b) your email app opens with the review text ready to send. 💬 Example: *"Update the form so it submits to Formspree. Use this endpoint: https://formspree.io/f/your-code-here, and change the button text to 'Send my review'."*

Step 7 — Preview it and tweak what you don't like

Right-click your `index.html` file in the left panel and pick **"Open in browser"** (or look near the top of the file's tab for a small browser icon). A new tab opens showing your form. Try filling it out and submitting to see how it behaves. If "Open in browser" isn't there, look at the bottom-right corner of the editor for a small **"Go Live"** or **"Live Preview"** icon — Codespaces sometimes hides it there. You'll know it worked when your form looks decent on screen, the fields are easy to click, and submitting it doesn't show an error. If something looks off, go back to Copilot Chat and describe the problem in plain words — for example: *"The submit button is too small on phones — make it bigger."*

Common mistakes

- **Pasting the code back into the chat instead of the file.** Many beginners paste Copilot's reply into the chat again, creating an endless loop. The fix: click into the empty editor area before pressing paste, then save with Ctrl+S.
- **Forgetting to save.** Codespaces often auto-saves, but not always. The fix: glance at the file tab — if there's a dot or asterisk next to the filename, it isn't saved yet. Press Ctrl+S to be sure.
- **Trusting every line Copilot writes.** Copilot is helpful but it makes mistakes — it might invent a field name, miss a closing tag, or use outdated HTML. The fix: read the suggested code, run the preview, and ask Copilot to fix anything weird instead of just pasting and publishing.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** you can swap the example prompt for any small thing on your site — a contact form, a "Book a table" button, an FAQ section — and Copilot does the same job. Once you've done this once, the second form takes half the time.
- **For your business or work:** a simple review form you control (no monthly fee to a third-party tool) is a small but real upgrade. You own the code, you can change it any time, and you can hand it to a developer later if you outgrow it.
- **If you're just getting started:** the easiest first move is exactly what Step 1 says — open a Codespace, name it `review-form`, and type your prompt into the chat. Twenty minutes from now you'll have a working page.

Try it now

Open github.com/codespaces, start a blank Codespace, and paste this exact prompt into Copilot Chat: *"Make me a clean, friendly HTML page with a 'Leave a review' form. Fields: name, star rating 1–5, and a comment box. Add a 'Submit review' button and simple warm styling."* Save the file, hit preview, and see what Copilot hands you in under a minute.

How to Clean Up a Flooded Email Inbox Using AI in One Afternoon

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** You can use any AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, or Copilot) to group your unread email into folders and write a one-paragraph summary of what needs attention today. Most people finish in under three hours.

By the end of this guide, you'll have a tidy inbox with folders that make sense, plus a single short paragraph at the top telling you what actually matters right now. The AI does the thinking; you do the clicking.

Before you start

- An account with any AI assistant you can already use — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, or Le Chat all work. The free version is enough.
- Your email account (Gmail, Outlook, Yahoo, Apple Mail, anything) open in a web browser.
- About 2–3 hours of quiet time — most of it is waiting, not typing.
- A notes app or blank document where you can paste text (Notepad, Google Docs, Notes — anything that saves text).

Step 1 — Pick which AI you'll use, and open it in a new tab

Open the AI assistant of your choice in a browser tab and sign in. You'll see a chat box at the bottom of the screen with a blank text field waiting for your first message. The conversation is private to you — nothing you paste is sent back to your email provider.

If you've never used one before, ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini are all safe picks. The free version is plenty for this task; paid plans just let you paste longer messages. If you can't find your bookmark, search "[tool name] login" in Google — the first result is almost always the real site.

Example: open chatgpt.com, claude.ai, gemini.google.com, or copilot.microsoft.com.

You'll know it worked when you see a typing box with a "Send" arrow or paper-plane icon, and the AI greets you when you say hello.

Step 2 — Make a copy of your unread emails the AI can read

In your email account, search for `is:unread` (Gmail), `unread:true` (Outlook web), or use the "Unread" filter in the left sidebar. The screen fills with every message you've ignored — that's your starting pile.

Pick the most recent 50–100 unread emails. Copy the subject lines and senders into a plain text document with `Ctrl+C` (Windows) or `Cmd+C` (Mac). If your email client offers "Export to .csv" for the unread folder, that's even faster — but only export unread mail, never your whole account.

Example: in Gmail, tick the checkbox at the top of the inbox. If a "Select all conversations" link appears, click it. Open the ⋯ menu and choose "Export."

You'll know it worked when you have a file with rows like "Sender — Subject — Date — first 2 lines."

Step 3 — Ask the AI to group the emails into 5–7 folders

Switch back to your AI tab and paste the list in. Then ask it to suggest a folder structure — copy the prompt below as-is.

The AI will respond with a small list of folder names (5–7 is the sweet spot — too many and you stop using them) and which emails belong where. It will not move anything itself; it only suggests. That part is still on you.

Example prompt: *"Here is a list of my unread emails. Group them into 5–7 folder names that make sense, and tell me which emails go in which folder. Use plain folder names a normal person would understand. Don't add explanations yet — just the list."*

You'll know it worked when you see something like: "Personal & Family — 12 emails. Bills & Receipts — 8 emails. Work — 27 emails. Newsletters — 41 emails. Calendar & RSVPs — 6 emails."

Step 4 — Create those folders in your email client

In your email account, create the folders the AI suggested. Most email apps have a "+" or "Create new label/folder" button in the left sidebar — if you don't see it, right-click an existing folder name and look for "New label," "New folder," or "Create."

Name them exactly as the AI wrote them, with the same spelling and capitalization. Lowercase, plural, no emoji — keeping it boring makes it stick. If the AI suggested something like "WorkStuff" and you'd prefer "Work," rename it now. The point is a structure you'll actually use.

Example: in Gmail, look in the left sidebar, scroll to "Labels," click the "+" next to it, and type "Bills & Receipts." In Outlook web, right-click "Folders" in the sidebar and choose "New folder."

You'll know it worked when every new folder name shows up in the sidebar, ready to receive mail.

Step 5 — Move messages into folders, starting with the small groups

Go back to your inbox and tackle the smallest group first — usually "Calendar & RSVPs" or "Personal." Open each email, click "Move to," and pick the matching folder. Do not read anything. The goal is an empty inbox, not total comprehension.

For the biggest group (often "Newsletters"), speed this up: search `category:promotions` (Gmail), `category:updates`, or use the bulk-select checkbox at the top of the list, then choose "Move to" → "Newsletters." This is the only step that feels slow — the rest is fast.

Example: type `label:unread from:newsletter` in the search box, select all results, move them to your "Newsletters" folder in one click.

You'll know it worked when your main inbox counter shows a much smaller number than before, and the moved messages no longer appear in the inbox list.

Step 6 — Ask the AI to write your "what matters now" summary

Now paste the remaining urgent emails (the ones still in your inbox, or the Work and Personal folders) back into the AI and ask it to write a short paragraph telling you what actually needs attention today.

The AI is good at this — it sorts through noise, spots deadlines and asks, and skips pleasantries. Your job is to give it enough context: who is waiting on you, what is due this week, what can wait a month.

Example prompt: *"Here are the remaining unread emails. Write me one short paragraph (under 100 words) telling me what I actually need to act on today, what's due this week, and what I can ignore. Start with the most urgent."*

You'll know it worked when the AI returns a single paragraph beginning with the deadline or action that's most urgent, like: "Reply to the school about Thursday pickup by tomorrow morning — they need a yes or no. Confirm the dentist appointment on Friday. Ignore the three shipping notifications..."

Step 7 — Pin that summary somewhere you'll see it

Take the paragraph the AI wrote and put it where your eyes land first in the morning. The easiest spot: the very top of your inbox (most email apps let you "Pin" or "Star" a message), or a sticky note on your desktop, or the first line of today's to-do list.

This is the whole point of the exercise. A clean inbox feels good for ten minutes — a clear "what matters now" keeps you focused all week. The folders are just a parking lot; the paragraph is the compass.

Example: copy the paragraph into a new email titled "Today" addressed to yourself, and pin it at the top of your inbox.

You'll know it worked when tomorrow morning, before you open any other email, you can read that one paragraph and know what to do first.

Common mistakes

- **Exporting your whole email account instead of just unread.** The AI does not need ten years of receipts to group your unread mail — and pasting your entire inbox into a chatbot is risky. Stick to unread, and only the last few hundred.
- **Letting the AI invent clever folder names like "CriticalPath_Q3_Items."** If a folder name is not something you'd write on a sticky note, change it. Boring folder names get used; clever ones get ignored.
- **Reading every email as you move it.** That's not cleanup, that's procrastination wearing a costume. Move first, read later — the summary tells you what actually matters.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** you'll stop dreading the inbox icon. The folder structure is a parking lot for things you don't need to act on; the summary is your morning compass.
- **For your work or business:** if you get a lot of client email, do this once a month. The folder names might shift slightly (a new project, a new client), but the pattern stays the same.
- **If you're just getting started:** pick one AI you already trust, do Steps 1–4 today, and save 5–7 for tomorrow. Two shorter sessions beat one exhausting one.

Try it now

Open your email account, search for unread messages, and copy the first 30 subject lines into your AI chat. Ask it for 5 folder names. That's it — ten minutes of work, and you'll already see the shape of the cleanup.

Check your resume for ATS-friendly keywords using Hugging Face's Inference API

7 steps · Read online

You'll learn how to scan your resume for keywords that applicant tracking systems (ATS) love, using free AI tools. This helps your resume get past the first filter and into a human's hands.

Before you start

- A **free Hugging Face account** (sign up here)
- A **resume in PDF or Word format** (saved on your device)
- A **computer or laptop** (phone works, but a larger screen is easier)
- **No coding skills needed** — this guide is for everyone
- **Total time:** about 10 minutes

💡 *What is ATS?* Think of it as a robot that scans your resume before a human does. It looks for keywords from the job ad. If your resume doesn't have enough of those words, it might get rejected before you even know.

Step 1 — Create a free Hugging Face account

Go to huggingface.co and click **Sign Up** in the top-right corner. Fill in your email, choose a username and password, then click **Create account**. Check your email and confirm your account.

You'll see your Hugging Face profile page. This is your dashboard — your home base for using AI models.

💬 Example:

```
Email: yourname@example.com
Username: resumehelper
Password: MyPassword123!
```

You'll know it worked when you see your profile picture and username in the top-right corner.

Step 2 — Open the Inference API page

On the Hugging Face homepage, look for **Products** in the top menu. Hover over it and click **Inference API**. This is a free tool that lets you run AI models without installing anything.

You'll see a page with a text box and a list of AI models. This is where you'll paste your job ad and resume.

💡 *What is an API?* Think of it like a waiter in a restaurant. You tell the waiter what you want (your job ad and resume), and the waiter brings it to the kitchen (the AI model) and brings back the answer — without you needing to cook.

You'll know it worked when you see a text box that says **Enter your prompt here** and a button that says **Submit**.

Step 3 — Choose an ATS-friendly keyword finder model

In the text box, type or paste this model name exactly:

```
microsoft/Phi-3-mini-4k-instruct
```

Then press **Enter** or click **Submit**.

This model is a smart AI assistant that can read your job ad and resume and tell you which keywords are missing.

💡 *What is a model?* Think of it like a super-smart student who has read thousands of job ads and resumes. It knows what words to look for.

You'll know it worked when you see a chat window open with a welcome message from the AI.

Step 4 — Write your job ad and resume into the chat

In the chat box, type or paste this exact prompt (copy the whole block):

```
I need help finding ATS-friendly keywords for a job application.
Here is the job ad:
```

```
[PASTE JOB AD HERE]

Here is my resume:
[PASTE RESUME TEXT HERE]

List the top 10 keywords from the job ad that are missing from my resume.
```

Replace `[PASTE JOB AD HERE]` with the full text of the job ad you're applying for. Replace `[PASTE RESUME TEXT HERE]` with the text of your resume. To copy text from a PDF, open the PDF, select the text, and press **Ctrl+C** (Windows) or **Cmd+C** (Mac). Paste it into the chat with **Ctrl+V** or **Cmd+V**.

💬 Example:

```
I need help finding ATS-friendly keywords for a job application.
Here is the job ad:
We are looking for a digital marketing specialist with experience in SEO, Google Analytics, and content creation.

Here is my resume:
I have 3 years of experience in digital marketing, including social media management and email campaigns.
```

You'll know it worked when the AI replies with a list of keywords, like:

> The top 10 keywords missing from your resume are: SEO, Google Analytics, content creation, PPC, keyword research, on-page optimization, conversion rate optimization, Google Ads, Ahrefs, backlink building.

Step 5 — Ask the AI to rewrite a sentence with the missing keywords

Copy one of the missing keywords from the AI's reply. Then, in the same chat, type:

```
Rewrite this sentence from my resume to include the keyword [KEYWORD]:
"I have 3 years of experience in digital marketing, including social media management and email campaigns."
```

Replace `[KEYWORD]` with the keyword you copied, like **SEO** or **Google Analytics**.

💬 Example:

```
Rewrite this sentence from my resume to include the keyword SEO:
"I have 3 years of experience in digital marketing, including social media management and email campaigns."
```

You'll know it worked when the AI replies with a rewritten sentence that includes the keyword naturally, like:

> I have 3 years of experience in digital marketing, including SEO strategy, social media management, and email campaigns.

Step 6 — Save your updated resume

Copy the rewritten sentence from the AI's reply. Open your resume file (Word or Google Docs), find the sentence you want to update, and paste the new version over it. Save the file with a new name like `Resume_ATS_Updated.pdf`.

💡 *Why save a new file?* This way, you always have your original resume to go back to if you need to.

You'll know it worked when you have a new file saved with your updated resume text.

Step 7 — Run the process again to double-check

Repeat Step 4 with your updated resume. Paste the same job ad and your new resume text into the chat. Ask the AI:

```
List the top 10 keywords from the job ad that are still missing from my resume.
```

You'll know it worked when the AI replies with a shorter list of missing keywords, or says:

> All the top keywords from the job ad are now included in your resume.

Common mistakes

- **Mistake:** Pasting the job ad or resume as an image or screenshot. **Fix:** Copy the text from the PDF or Word file and paste it as plain text. Images can't be read by the AI.
- **Mistake:** Using a phone to copy and paste large blocks of text. **Fix:** On a phone, it's easy to lose your place. Use a computer or laptop if you can. If you must use a phone, paste smaller chunks of text at a time.
- **Mistake:** Expecting the AI to rewrite your whole resume perfectly in one go. **Fix:** The AI is great at spotting missing keywords, but it can't rewrite your whole resume in one sentence. Update one sentence at a time, then check again.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** You'll spend less time guessing which keywords to add to your resume. The AI does the hard work for you, so you can focus on the rest of your job application.
- **For your business or work:** If you're hiring, you can use this same method to check if your job ads include the right keywords. It helps attract candidates whose resumes will pass the ATS filter.
- **If you're just getting started:** This is the easiest first move to make your resume ATS-friendly. No coding, no expensive tools — just free AI and a few minutes of your time.

Try it now

Open your resume file and copy the first sentence. Go to huggingface.co, open the Inference API, and paste this prompt:

```
I need help finding ATS-friendly keywords for a job application.
Here is the job ad:
[PASTE A JOB AD YOU'RE APPLYING FOR]

Here is my resume:
[PASTE THE FIRST SENTENCE OF YOUR RESUME]

List the top 5 keywords from the job ad that are missing from my resume.
```

Press **Submit** and see what the AI suggests. You'll have your first ATS keyword list in under 2 minutes.

Write a Polite Complaint Email to a Company with DeepSeek

7 steps · Read online

> **In short:** DeepSeek can draft a polite, well-structured complaint email in under a minute — but you'll need to add the real details (order numbers, dates, names) and send it from your own account. It can't contact the company for you.

When something goes wrong with a product or service, the email you write in frustration usually gets ignored. A short, calm message that says what happened, what you want, and by when is far more likely to get a real reply. DeepSeek is great at shaping that kind of message — you describe the problem in your own words, and it turns your rambling into a clean, firm but polite email.

Before you start

- A phone, tablet, or computer with internet access.
- A web browser (Chrome, Safari, Edge, Firefox — any modern one). Or the DeepSeek app if you prefer.
- A rough idea of what went wrong: when it happened, what you bought, and what you'd like the company to do about it.
- Any order numbers, receipts, or screenshots handy (helpful, but not required).
- About 10 to 15 minutes total.

Step 1 — Open DeepSeek in your browser

Go to **chat.deepseek.com** in your web browser. The page loads a chat screen with a text box near the bottom labeled something like "Send a message" or "Message DeepSeek." No account is needed for a basic chat, so you can start typing right away. If you have the DeepSeek app installed, open it instead and you'll see the same chat layout. Example: type nothing yet — just confirm the box is there. You'll know it worked when the chat screen is empty and ready, with a blinking cursor in the message box.

Step 2 — Describe what happened in plain words

In the chat box, write a short, honest summary of the problem. Don't worry about grammar or politeness — just dump the facts the way you'd tell a friend. Include the company name, the product or service, when it happened, and what went wrong. DeepSeek reads everything in this message and uses it to draft the email later. Example: "I bought a coffee maker from BrewCo on March 12, order #44291. It arrived broken — the carafe was cracked and water leaks everywhere. I emailed them a week ago and nobody replied. I want a replacement or a full refund." You'll know it worked when DeepSeek replies by asking a follow-up question or jumping straight into a draft. If it asks "What outcome do you want?", move to Step 3.

Step 3 — Ask for a polite complaint email

Type a clear follow-up: "Please turn this into a polite complaint email I can send to the company. Keep it firm but respectful, around 150 words, with a subject line." DeepSeek now produces a full email — greeting, body paragraphs, and a sign-off — usually in a couple of seconds. The subject line usually appears at the top. Example: "Please turn this into a polite complaint email I can send to BrewCo customer service. Keep it firm but respectful, around 150 words, and give me a subject line too." You'll know it worked when you see a complete email in the chat, with a "Subject:" line, a "Dear..." greeting, and a closing like "Sincerely."

Step 4 — Tell DeepSeek what outcome you want

The first draft is usually generic. Tell DeepSeek specifically what you want the company to do — a refund, a replacement, an apology, a callback, a coupon. The clearer you are, the more useful the next draft becomes. You can also mention a reasonable deadline, like "within 7 business days." Example: "Please rewrite it so I clearly ask for a full refund of $89 within 7 business days, and mention that if I don't hear back I'll file a chargeback with my bank. Keep the same polite tone." You'll know it worked when the new version includes your specific ask, in plain language, not a vague "I hope you can help."

Step 5 — Adjust the tone if needed

Read the email out loud. Does it sound like you? If it's too stiff, say "make it sound warmer and more conversational." If it's too soft and you want to sound firmer, say "make the tone more direct without being rude." DeepSeek rewrites the whole email in seconds, so don't be shy about asking two or three times. Example: "Make it a bit warmer — I'm not angry, just disappointed. Keep the firmness but add one sentence saying I have liked their products in the past." You'll know it worked when the new version feels like something you'd actually be comfortable sending under your own name.

Step 6 — Add your real details and read it carefully

Now do the human part. Open the email in your own mail app (Gmail, Outlook, Apple Mail — anything), and copy the draft over. Fill in the missing pieces: the actual recipient email (usually support@example.com or a contact form address), the real order number, dates, your name, and any return or tracking numbers. Read it once more to make sure it sounds like you and every fact is correct. Example: replace "[Your

Name]" with your real name, "[Order #]" with the real order number, and double-check the dollar amounts. You'll know it worked when the email reads as a complete, accurate message with no placeholder text like "[insert date here]."

Step 7 — Send the email from your own account

Hit send from your own email account. DeepSeek can't send emails for you — it's a chat tool, not a mail program. After sending, keep the message handy; if you don't hear back in the time you mentioned (often 5 to 7 business days), you can simply reply to your own thread with "Just following up on my email below." Example: write a short follow-up — "Hi, I'm following up on my email from March 20 about order #44291. I haven't received a reply yet. Please let me know how you'd like to resolve this." You'll know it worked when the email lands in your "Sent" folder and you have a copy you can quote later if needed.

Common mistakes

- **Being too angry in the prompt.** DeepSeek often mirrors the tone of what you give it. If you rant, you may get a rant back. Stay matter-of-fact and let the tool do the polishing.
- **Forgetting the specific ask.** A complaint that doesn't say "refund, replacement, or reply by Friday" often gets a generic "we're sorry" reply. Always name what you want.
- **Sending without reading.** AI drafts sometimes invent details — a wrong date, a fake policy, a tone that isn't yours. Always read it once, top to bottom, before sending.
- **No receipt of what you sent.** Screenshot or forward the final email to yourself so you have proof of what was said and when.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** A broken toaster, a missed delivery, a noisy hotel room, a wrong phone bill — any of these can become a 10-minute fix instead of a week of ignored messages.
- **For your business or work:** If you invoice or buy from other companies, the same trick works for late payments, missing deliveries, or poor service. A polite, specific email usually beats a phone call.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick the smallest, most recent annoyance and try one email. You'll see how much easier it is when you don't have to start from a blank page.

Try it now

Think of one small frustration from the last month — a delayed package, a wrong charge, a rude reply from a store. Open DeepSeek, type two sentences about what happened, and ask it to turn that into a polite email. Read the draft, fix one detail, and save it in your drafts folder. You'll have a real, ready-to-send message in under five minutes.

Drafting Professional Presentations from Scratch Using Microsoft Copilot in PowerPoint

7 steps · Read online

Imagine turning a messy idea or a blank slide deck into a polished, ready-to-use presentation in under 10 minutes. With Microsoft Copilot in PowerPoint, you can draft outlines, generate slide titles, and fill in speaker notes—all from a simple prompt. This guide walks you through every step, from opening PowerPoint to exporting your finished slides.

Before you start

- A **Microsoft 365 account** (free or paid)
- The **PowerPoint desktop app** (Windows or Mac) or **PowerPoint on the web**
- A **device with internet access**
- Roughly **10–15 minutes** of your time
- Optional: a **Microsoft 365 Copilot license** (paid) for full features

> ⚠️ Note: Some Copilot features may require a paid Microsoft 365 Copilot license. If you don't have it, you'll still be able to use basic Copilot features like generating outlines and slide titles.

Step 1 — Open PowerPoint and start a new presentation

Open the **PowerPoint app** on your computer or go to PowerPoint on the web. Click **New blank presentation** to start with a blank slide deck.

You'll see a single slide titled "Click to add title." The ribbon at the top shows tabs like **Home**, **Insert**, and **Design**.

If you don't see the **Home** tab, look for a menu at the top with words like **File**, **Home**, or **View**.

You'll know it worked when you see a blank slide with a title and subtitle placeholder.

Step 2 — Open Copilot in the PowerPoint ribbon

On the **Home** tab in the ribbon, look for a button labeled **Copilot** (it looks like a sparkle or a chat bubble with stars). Click it to open the Copilot pane on the right side of your screen.

You'll see a chat box that says "Ask me anything about this document." This is where you'll type your instructions.

If you don't see the Copilot button, make sure you're using the latest version of PowerPoint. Look for **File > Account > Update Options > Update Now**.

You'll know it worked when the Copilot pane opens on the right with a blinking cursor ready for your prompt.

💬 Example: Type or paste:

```
Help me create a presentation about the benefits of remote work for a team of 20 software developers.
```

Step 3 — Give Copilot a clear prompt to generate an outline

In the Copilot chat box, type a clear, specific prompt. Include:

- Your **topic**
- Your **audience**
- Any **key points** you want covered

After you press Enter, Copilot will process your request and show a message like "Generating outline..." in the pane.

You'll see a new section titled **Outline** appear in the Copilot pane, with 4–6 suggested slide titles and bullet points.

If the outline isn't quite right, you can type:

```
Add a slide about work-life balance and another about team collaboration tools.
```

You'll know it worked when you see a structured outline with slide titles and bullet points in the Copilot pane.

💬 Example:

```
Create an outline for a 10-minute presentation on 'How Remote Work Boosts Developer Productivity'. Include slides on flexibility, tools, and
```

Step 4 — Insert the outline into your slides

Click the **Add to presentation** button under the outline in the Copilot pane. Copilot will automatically create new slides based on the outline.

You'll see your slide deck grow from one blank slide to 5–7 slides with titles and bullet points.

If the slides look too plain, don't worry—you can edit them later. If the Copilot pane disappears, click the **Copilot** button again to reopen it.

You'll know it worked when you see multiple slides with titles and bullet points in your deck.

Step 5 — Ask Copilot to generate speaker notes for each slide

Select the first slide. In the Copilot pane, type:

```
Add speaker notes to this slide explaining the benefits of remote work for developers.
```

Copilot will write 2–3 sentences of speaker notes under the slide. Repeat this for each slide by selecting it and asking Copilot to add notes.

You'll see a small note icon appear on each slide. Click the icon to read the notes.

If speaker notes don't appear, make sure you've selected the slide first. If Copilot doesn't respond, refresh the pane or check your internet connection.

You'll know it worked when you see speaker notes appear under each slide.

Example: For a slide titled "Flexibility," Copilot might add:

```
Speaker notes: Remote work lets developers choose their most productive hours. Studies show 60% of developers report higher focus at home. M
```

Step 6 — Refine content with follow-up prompts

With the outline and notes in place, ask Copilot to improve or expand any slide. For example:

```
Rewrite the slide titled 'Team Collaboration Tools' to include specific examples like Microsoft Teams and GitHub.
```

Copilot will update the slide content in real time. You can also ask it to:

- Shorten the text
- Add a quote
- Include a data point

You'll see the slide content change immediately after you press Enter.

If Copilot doesn't update the slide, try clicking **Refresh** in the Copilot pane or re-selecting the slide.

You'll know it worked when the slide content updates to match your new prompt.

Example:

```
Add a quote from Satya Nadella about remote work culture to the last slide.
```

Step 7 — Export or present your presentation

When you're happy with the slides, save your presentation (**File > Save As**). To present, click **Slide Show > From Current Slide** or press **F5**.

You'll see your slides full-screen, ready to present.

If you want to share it, go to **File > Share > Send a Copy** to export as PDF or PowerPoint file.

You'll know it worked when you can present or share a complete, professional-looking deck.

Common mistakes

- **Mistake:** Writing a vague prompt like "Make a presentation." **Fix:** Be specific: include topic, audience, and key points. Example: "Create a 5-slide presentation on AI tools for small business owners."

- **Mistake:** Expecting Copilot to write perfect content in one try. **Fix:** Use follow-up prompts to refine slides. Ask Copilot to shorten, add data, or include a quote.
- **Mistake:** Not checking speaker notes or slide content for accuracy. **Fix:** Always review Copilot's output. Edit or remove anything that doesn't fit your message.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Need to present a project update at work? Use Copilot to draft slides in minutes instead of hours. Great for team meetings, client pitches, or internal reviews.
- **For your business or work:** Create consistent, professional presentations without hiring a designer. Use it for quarterly reviews, training decks, or onboarding materials.
- **If you're just getting started:** Start with a simple prompt and let Copilot do the heavy lifting. You'll save time and look polished—even if you're not a designer.

Try it now

Open PowerPoint, start a new presentation, and open Copilot. Type:

```
Help me create a 5-slide presentation about the benefits of remote work for a team of 20 software developers.
```

Press Enter. Review the outline, add it to your slides, and start presenting in under 10 minutes.

Digitize Handwritten Notes into Editable Text with AI

6 steps · Read online

Do you have notebooks full of brilliant ideas, meeting notes, or shopping lists that you can never quite find when you need them? This guide will show you how to quickly turn those physical scribbles into digital text using AI, so they're always searchable and editable, right on your phone or computer. It's for anyone who wants to bring order to their paper notes without retyping a single word. While AI is great at "reading" your handwriting, it can't understand *meaning* or summarize for you yet – it just converts the words.

Before you start

- **A smartphone or tablet with a working camera.** Ensure your device has enough battery life and storage for a few photos.
- **Access to an app that offers AI-powered OCR.** This means **Optical Character Recognition**, a technology that "reads" text from images. Think of it like a very clever digital assistant looking at your picture and identifying each letter and word, then turning it into text you can actually edit. The "AI-powered" part means it uses advanced artificial intelligence to understand different handwritings and layouts, making it much more accurate than older systems. Many free note-taking or scanning apps now include this feature, such as Google Keep (available on Android and iOS) or Microsoft OneNote (available on Android and iOS).
- **A free Google or Microsoft account.** You'll likely need one of these to use the apps suggested, though you probably already have one set up on your device. Ensure you're logged in before you start.
- **Roughly 5-10 minutes** to follow these steps for your first digitized note.

Step 1 — Prepare your notes for capture

Before you take a photo, you need to set up your handwritten notes in a way that helps the AI "read" them clearly. You'll see your physical notes lying on a surface. Your goal is to give the AI the best possible image to work with, as good, even lighting and legible handwriting make a big difference for the AI to understand your scribbles correctly. Think of it like a librarian trying to read tiny, smudged print – the clearer, the better!

Once prepared, your notes will be ready for you to take a photo. If your usual handwriting is quite messy, try to write a little slower and clearer for important notes you plan to digitize, as this significantly improves the AI's accuracy.

Example: Place your handwritten notes on a plain, uncluttered surface, like a clear desk. Position them under natural light from a window, if possible, or use a well-lit lamp to avoid casting shadows over your writing. Make sure the paper is flat and smooth, with no creases. You'll know it worked when your notes are lying flat, look easy to read in the available light, and are clear of any distracting objects, ready for a photo.

Step 2 — Open your scanning app

Now it's time to open your chosen app. You'll see your device's home screen with various app icons. You need to locate and tap on the icon for your OCR app. For this guide, we'll use Google Keep as the primary example, which is free and widely available. Microsoft OneNote is another option that includes document scanning. Once opened, the app will load, often showing your existing notes or presenting a default view.

If you don't already have one of these apps, you'll need to download it from your device's app store (Google Play Store for Android or Apple App Store for iOS) and install it first. Look for the app icon, which usually looks like a colorful note for Google Keep or a blue notebook icon for Microsoft OneNote.

Example: Tap the "Google Keep" app icon on your home screen or app drawer (it looks like a yellow and white notepad). Alternatively, tap the "Microsoft OneNote" app icon (a blue notebook icon). You'll know it worked when the app opens and you see its main interface, such as a list of notes or a camera view, indicating it's ready for you to take action.

Step 3 — Take a clear photo

With your chosen app open, you'll typically see options to create a new note or use the camera. You need to find and tap the camera or scan icon to activate your device's camera within the app. The screen will then switch to a camera interface, often with specific modes like "Document" or "Scan" in apps like OneNote to help you capture text accurately.

Position your device directly above your notes, aiming for a straight-on shot without shadows, ensuring all your writing fits within the frame. Then, tap the shutter button. The app will capture the image, and some might even automatically detect the edges of your document and crop the image for you, making it look neater.

Example: In Google Keep, tap the plus (+) icon at the bottom of the screen, then choose the camera icon (it might be labeled 'Take photo' or 'Image'). In Microsoft OneNote, select 'Camera' from the options at the bottom, then hold your phone steady over your notes and tap the shutter button. You'll know it worked when you see a sharp, unblurred image of your notes presented within the app, often with the document edges automatically detected and cropped, ready for the next step.

Step 4 — Initiate text recognition with AI

With your clear photo captured in the app, it's time for the AI-powered OCR to do its magic. You'll typically see your captured image on the screen, possibly with a menu or a button related to text. You need to find and tap an option that tells the app to "read" the text from the image. This button might say something like "Scan text," "Recognize text," "Grab image text," or simply show a 'T' icon.

Once you activate this function, the AI will process the image you've taken, which usually takes just a few seconds. A new screen or panel will then appear, displaying your handwritten words now typed out as digital text. If you don't see an obvious "Grab image text" button, try tapping on the image itself, or look for a three-dot menu (⋯) or a gear icon ( ) that might contain the option you need.

Example: In Google Keep, after your photo is captured, tap on the image to view it full screen. Then, look for a three-dot menu (⋯) in the top-right corner of the screen and tap the option labeled 'Grab image text'. In Microsoft OneNote, after taking a photo, tap the 'Text' icon that appears on the captured image to extract the text. You'll know it worked when a new text box or a separate screen appears, displaying your handwritten words now typed out as digital text, ready for you to review.

Step 5 — Review and make corrections

The AI is incredibly smart, but it's not perfect! Especially with unique handwriting, faint lines, or unusual symbols, it might make a few mistakes. You'll see the extracted text, usually in an editable field, displayed on your screen. Take a moment to read through this digitized text carefully and correct any errors.

As you make corrections, the text on your screen will update instantly, just like in any word processor. If the text isn't directly editable, look for an "Edit" button or a cursor you can tap to activate the editing mode. Remember, the AI is a great starting point, but it usually cannot perfectly capture every nuance of human handwriting, so your review is crucial for accuracy and ensures your digital notes are truly useful.

Example: Carefully read through the digitized text. If you spot a word like "flow" incorrectly appearing as "flew," tap on "flew" and type "flow" to correct it. Also, remove any extra spaces, line breaks, or unwanted characters the AI might have picked up from smudges or background textures on the paper. You'll know it worked when you've corrected all the obvious mistakes, and the digital text accurately reflects your original handwritten notes, making them much clearer than your original scrawl.

Step 6 — Save or export your editable text

After reviewing and correcting your digitized notes, you can now save them or share them. You'll see options on your screen to save the note within the app, copy the text to your device's clipboard, or share it to other applications. This final step means your old scribbles are now **editable text** (you can change it whenever you like) and **searchable text** (your device can find it instantly when you search).

Once you take action, your app will usually confirm that the note has been saved, or the text will be transferred to your chosen destination. If you don't see an explicit "Save" button, look for an arrow pointing left (←) or a "Done" button, which will usually save your changes within the app you're using. Free versions of apps might have limits on how many notes you can save or what export options are available, but basic saving and copying are almost always free.

Example: Tap the 'Save' or 'Done' button within your chosen app to store the note. Alternatively, look for a 'Share' icon (often a three-dot connection or an upward-pointing arrow) to copy the text to your phone's clipboard or send it directly to an email, a document app like Google Docs or Microsoft Word, or cloud storage like Google Drive or OneDrive. You'll know it worked when your app confirms the note is saved (e.g., you see it in your main notes list), or when you successfully paste the text into another application, ready for editing, searching, or sharing.

Common mistakes

- **Poor lighting or blurry photos:** Shadows or dim light make it incredibly hard for the AI to "read" your notes accurately, and blurry images are almost impossible for it to decipher. Always aim for bright, even light, and hold your phone steady when taking the picture. If the first attempt is blurry, simply delete it and retake the photo.
- **Not reviewing the extracted text:** It's easy to assume the AI got it all right, but even the best AI can make mistakes, especially with unique handwriting or complex layouts. A quick check and correction can save you from future confusion or embarrassment when you try to use the notes later. Always perform a quick read-through.
- **Using an app without a strong OCR feature:** Not all camera or note-taking apps have robust AI-powered OCR. If your results are consistently bad (lots of errors, missing text), try downloading a dedicated scanning app like Google Keep or Microsoft OneNote, which are known for good text recognition capabilities.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Imagine quickly finding that recipe idea you scribbled down weeks ago, or having a digital copy of your kids' school notes that you can share instantly with a co-parent. No more rummaging through stacks of paper! This tool helps you keep important information organized and accessible, whether it's a shopping list, a quick thought, or important reminders.
- **For your business or work:** Effortlessly convert meeting notes, brainstorming sessions, or client feedback from paper to a digital format. This makes them searchable, easy to share with colleagues, and simple to integrate into digital documents, saving you valuable time on

transcription.

- **If you're just getting started:** Pick one short, clearly written note – like a shopping list or a phone number – and try to digitize it. It's a low-pressure way to see how well the AI works with your handwriting.

Try it now

Grab a piece of paper and quickly jot down three items on your grocery list. Now, open Google Keep (or Microsoft OneNote), take a clear photo of your list, and use the app's text recognition feature. In less than two minutes, you'll have your shopping list in an editable format, ready to paste into a messaging app or email!

How to turn a long PDF contract into a plain-English summary in 5 minutes

6 steps · Read online

> **In short:** Open any AI assistant that accepts PDF uploads, attach the file, and ask a few focused questions about deadlines, fees, and cancellation. You'll get a plain-English summary in minutes — but always read the original key clauses yourself, because AI summaries can miss important details.

Contracts hide the important parts deep in the small print: the auto-renewal clause, the 30-day cancellation window, the fee that "may apply" later. An AI assistant can pull all of that into a short, readable summary, but only if you ask the right questions. This guide shows the technique that works in any major AI assistant that accepts PDF uploads — ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Copilot, Le Chat, and others.

Before you start

- An AI assistant that can read PDF files you upload. Most major assistants do this on their free tier, but very long contracts (over roughly 100 pages) may need a paid plan. Check the upload limit on the assistant's pricing page if your document is unusually long.
- The contract itself, saved as a PDF on your computer or phone.
- About 10 minutes. The summary itself is fast; the careful read-through at the end takes a moment.
- A quiet moment to actually read what the assistant tells you.

Step 1 — Start a fresh chat and upload the PDF

Open your AI assistant and begin a brand-new conversation. A clean slate gives you the cleanest answer — older chats can confuse what the assistant reads in the new document. Once the chat is open, look for a **paperclip**, **attachment**, or **plus icon** near the message box. Tap that, then choose the PDF from your files. Some assistants also let you drag and drop the file straight onto the chat window.

If you don't see a paperclip, look for a **+ icon** or a button labeled something like **Add files** or **Upload**. On phone apps the icon often hides inside a small menu at the side of the text box.

Example: "I'm uploading a contract. Please don't analyze it yet — I'll ask my questions one at a time."

You'll know it worked when the file name appears above the message box (or as a small chip beside it) and the assistant confirms it can see the document. If nothing happens after 30 seconds, the file may be too large — check the assistant's file-size limit before assuming the tool is broken.

Step 2 — Ask for a plain-English overview first

Before you drill into the details, ask the assistant to give you a one-paragraph summary of what the document is, who it's between, and what it covers. This grounds the rest of the conversation: once the assistant has the big picture in mind, its later answers tend to be more accurate. Type your question in the message box where the uploaded file is already attached, and press Enter or the send arrow.

If the answer is longer than a paragraph or feels like a sales pitch, ask it to "shorten to one paragraph and skip the legal jargon." If the assistant gives you only a vague intro, ask a follow-up: "What kind of contract is this — a service agreement, a lease, a sales contract, or something else?"

Example: "In plain English, what is this document, who are the parties, and what is the main thing being agreed to?"

You'll know it worked when the assistant gives you back a short paragraph (3 to 6 sentences) that names the type of contract, the people or companies involved, and the core purpose. If any of those three is missing, ask one more focused question before moving on.

Step 3 — Ask the three questions that actually matter

Now the real work. In the same chat, type three focused questions, one after another: **deadlines** (when does this start, when can I leave, when does it auto-renew), **fees** (what does it cost, what changes after the first period, what extra charges might apply), and **cancellation** (how do I end this, what's the notice period, what happens if I miss it). Ask all three in one message so the assistant can answer them together. Press Enter and wait — usually under a minute.

If the assistant answers only one of the three, send the missing questions in a fresh message. If the answer feels too short, ask "Please list every date, dollar amount, and cancellation step you can find in the document."

Example: "From this contract, list: 1) every deadline or time limit I need to know, 2) every fee, charge, or price that might apply, and 3) exactly how I cancel, including any notice period. Use bullet points."

You'll know it worked when the assistant gives you a structured, easy-to-scan answer with three clear sections. If any answer is "I can't find that in the document," ask it to point to the page or section it looked at — sometimes the answer is there and the assistant missed it.

Step 4 — Push for the things people forget to ask

Once you have the big three, push one more layer. Contracts hide risk in the small print: what happens if you miss a payment, who pays legal fees in a dispute, whether the company can change terms mid-contract, and which country's laws apply. Ask these as a follow-up message in the same chat. The assistant now has the document **and** your earlier answers in its context window (the conversation history it can refer to), so it can build on what it already told you.

If the assistant's answer feels generic, paste in the actual clause: "I'm looking at section 8.2. What does this mean in plain English, and what's the worst-case scenario for me?"

Example: "What happens if I miss a payment, who covers legal fees in a dispute, can the company change the terms mid-contract, and which state's laws apply? Point me to the section for each."

You'll know it worked when the assistant points to specific sections or page numbers and explains each risk in a sentence a non-lawyer can follow. If it just says "this is a standard clause" without explaining the actual risk, ask "what's the worst that could happen to me, in concrete terms?"

Step 5 — Ask for a one-page checklist you can save

Now ask the assistant to compress everything into a short, printable checklist you can keep next to the contract. A checklist is easier to skim than a long summary, and it's the format most people actually re-read later. Ask in the same chat — the assistant still has the document and your earlier conversation. The result should fit on one screen: action items, key dates, and money amounts, plain and short.

If the checklist comes back too long, ask it to "cut this to the 10 most important items I'd forget in six months."

Example: "Summarize everything we just found into a one-page checklist I can save: dates I must remember, amounts I'll be charged, and the steps to cancel. Keep it under 15 lines."

You'll know it worked when you can copy the answer into a notes app and read it in under a minute. If the checklist still feels like a wall of text, ask the assistant to put each item on its own line with the date or amount in bold.

Step 6 — Spot-check three sections in the original PDF

AI summaries are good, but they're not perfect. The assistant can misread a clause, skip a footnote, or paraphrase something in a way that changes the meaning. Before you rely on the summary, open the original PDF and read three things yourself: the **cancellation clause** (usually labeled "Termination"), the **fees section** (often "Fees," "Charges," or "Payment Terms"), and any **date or deadline** the assistant flagged. If those three match what the assistant told you, the rest of the summary is very likely accurate.

If you can't find the section the assistant mentioned, use the PDF's search function (Ctrl+F on a computer, or the magnifying glass icon in most phone PDF apps) and type a keyword from the clause. If something doesn't match, send a follow-up question: "Section X says something different — can you re-read and reconcile?"

Example: "Cancellation clause says 30 days, fees say a charge after year one, and auto-renewal is 60 days before expiration — can you re-read sections 7, 9, and 12 and tell me if your summary matches?"

You'll know it worked when the three sections you read match the summary, and you feel comfortable either signing the contract or deciding not to. If anything is off, send the assistant the exact text and ask it to explain the difference — that's how you catch the small print that changes everything.

Common mistakes

- **Asking one giant question.** A single "summarize this contract" prompt usually gives a vague, hard-to-scan answer. Splitting it into overview, the three big questions, the hidden risks, and a checklist gets you a result you can actually use.
- **Trusting the summary without checking.** AI assistants can misread clauses, especially around fees and dates. Always read the cancellation, fees, and deadline sections yourself before you sign. The summary is a map, not a replacement for the territory.
- **Letting a long chat get messy.** After 20 or 30 messages, the assistant can lose track of what it told you earlier. If the conversation gets long, copy the checklist into a new chat, re-upload the PDF, and start fresh. Cleaner chats give cleaner answers.
- **Skipping the free-tier limits.** Some assistants let you upload small files on the free plan but cap the size on paid plans. If your upload fails, check the assistant's file-size limit before assuming the tool is broken.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** Leasing a new apartment, renewing a phone plan, signing up for a gym membership — the same five-step question set works for any contract. Once you've done it twice, the second one takes about three minutes.
- **For your business or work:** Vendor agreements, client contracts, partnership letters, freelancer terms — all of these can be summarized the same way. The checklist step is especially useful when you need to brief a partner or a manager who hasn't read the document.
- **If you want to go further:** Try a second AI assistant on the same PDF and compare the two summaries. Two independent reads catch more than one — and they don't always agree on which clauses matter most. Just don't paste a confidential contract into a tool your

company hasn't approved for outside use.

Try it now

Pick the last contract you signed — apartment lease, phone plan, gym membership, anything with more than five pages. Upload it to your AI assistant and ask the three big questions from Step 3. Save the answer somewhere you can find it in six months, when the renewal notice arrives. You'll never read a long contract the same way again.

Unlock Document Insights with Google NotebookLM

6 steps · Read online

Imagine having a smart assistant that can read all your scattered notes, long reports, or important documents and then answer your questions using *only* the information you've provided. That's the power of Google NotebookLM. By the end of this guide, you'll be able to upload your own documents, ask intelligent questions, and quickly pull out key information or summaries without sifting through pages yourself. It's perfect for students, researchers, or anyone dealing with lots of text.

Before you start

- **A Google Account:** You'll need a standard Google account (like the one you use for Gmail or Google Drive) to access NotebookLM.
- **A Web Browser:** Access NotebookLM through a web browser on your computer. While it works on tablets, a computer provides the best experience for this guide.
- **An Internet Connection:** A stable connection is needed to upload documents and interact with the AI.
- **A few documents:** Have 1-3 documents (e.g., a PDF report, a text file of notes, or a Google Doc) ready to upload. These will be your "sources".
- **Cost:** NotebookLM is currently available for free.
- **Time:** This guide will take about 10-15 minutes to follow.

Step 1 — Access Google NotebookLM

First, you'll need to open Google NotebookLM in your web browser. This is where you'll create a dedicated space for your documents and questions. You'll see a welcome screen or an overview of your existing Notebooks, which are like individual project folders. If you're logged into your Google account, it should open directly. If it asks you to sign in, use your Google account details.

If it looks different: If you see a welcome tour or introductory pop-ups, simply click through them to get to the main interface. Look for a "Create new Notebook" or a large "+" button to start. **You'll know it worked when:** You see the NotebookLM interface, likely with a main content area and a sidebar, and perhaps a prompt to create your first Notebook.

Step 2 — Create a New Notebook

A "Notebook" in NotebookLM is like a digital binder where you keep all the related documents for a specific topic or project. It helps keep your information organized and ensures the AI only uses the sources relevant to that project. To create one, look for a prominent button or option to start a new project.

What you see: On the main screen, you'll typically find a large "New Notebook" button or a similar option in a sidebar. Clicking it usually prompts you to give your new Notebook a name. **What happens next:** A small pop-up window will appear, asking you to name your new workspace. Give it a descriptive title that reflects the documents you'll be adding, so you can easily find it later. **If it looks different:** If you don't see a "New Notebook" button, look for an icon like a "+", a folder, or text that says "Create". The exact placement might vary, but it's usually at the top or in a left-hand navigation pane. 💬 Example: `My Research Notes on Renewable Energy` **You'll know it worked when:** A new, empty Notebook with your chosen name appears on your screen, ready for you to add "sources".

Step 3 — Add Your Source Documents

"Sources" are the documents you want NotebookLM to read and analyze. These can be PDFs, Google Docs, text files, or even web pages saved as PDFs. The AI will then use *only* these sources to answer your questions, acting like a super-smart indexer for your own content. You can usually add multiple files to a single Notebook.

What you see: Inside your new Notebook, you'll see an area labeled "Sources" or "Add sources", often with an "Upload" button or an option to connect to Google Drive. Click the "Upload" button. **What happens next:** A file explorer window (or Google Drive selector) will open, allowing you to choose documents from your computer. Select one or more relevant files. NotebookLM will then process these files, which might take a few moments depending on their size and number. **If it looks different:** Look for an icon representing a document, a paperclip, or a cloud upload symbol if "Upload" isn't immediately visible. If you're using a Google Doc, there might be a direct integration option for Google Drive. **You'll know it worked when:** Your uploaded documents appear listed under the "Sources" section in your Notebook. You might see a "Processing" status initially, which will change to "Ready" when the AI has finished reading them.

Step 4 — Ask a Question Based on Your Sources

Now that NotebookLM has your documents, you can start asking it questions. Remember, the key here is that the AI (which is powered by a large language model, or LLM – a sophisticated computer program that understands and generates human-like text) will *only* refer to the information within the sources you provided. This prevents "hallucinations" – when an AI confidently makes up facts – and ensures its answers are grounded in your specific content.

What you see: In the main area of your Notebook, there's usually a chat box or a "Ask your sources" field, similar to what you'd find in a regular chat AI. Type your question here. **What happens next:** The AI will process your question, consult *only* the uploaded sources, and then generate an answer directly below your prompt. It will often include small citations (like "Source 1, Page 3") pointing back to where it found the information in your documents. **If it looks different:** The chat box might be labeled differently, perhaps "Query sources" or "Enter prompt". Just ensure you're typing your question into the area designated for interacting with your documents. 💬 Example: `What are the key challenges mentioned in the "Renewable Energy Report.pdf"?` **You'll know it worked when:** You receive a detailed answer from NotebookLM, specifically referencing your uploaded documents, with citations next to the relevant parts of its response.

Step 5 — Explore and Refine with Follow-up Questions

The conversation doesn't have to end with the first answer. NotebookLM is designed for back-and-forth interaction. If an answer is too broad, too short, or if you want to dive deeper into a specific point, you can ask follow-up questions. This helps you refine your understanding and extract exactly what you need.

What you see: After receiving an answer, the chat box typically remains open, or a "New prompt" button appears. You can type another question directly into this field, building on the previous interaction. **What happens next:** NotebookLM will take your new question and the context of your previous conversation into account, again pulling information solely from your sources. The new response will appear below the previous one, continuing the thread. **If it looks different:** If the chat box clears, simply re-type your follow-up question. The AI remembers the context of the current conversation within the Notebook. 💬 Example: `Can you summarise the solutions proposed for reducing these challenges?` **You'll know it worked when:** You get a new answer that directly addresses your follow-up question, further refining the information based on your sources, and continuing the conversational flow.

Step 6 — Generate an Overview or Summary

One of NotebookLM's most powerful features for a beginner is its ability to quickly generate an "Overview" or summary of your entire Notebook or specific documents. This is incredibly useful for getting the gist of large amounts of text without reading every word, or for quickly preparing for a meeting or study session.

What you see: Look for a button or option in your Notebook, often labeled "Overview", "Summarize Notebook", or "Generate Summary". It might be in the sidebar or at the top of the main conversation area. Click it. **What happens next:** NotebookLM will quickly process all the documents within that specific Notebook and generate a concise summary or a list of key topics and insights. This often appears as a new section or card in your Notebook interface. **If it looks different:** The feature might be represented by an icon, such as a bulleted list or a document with an arrow, or be found under a "Tools" or "More actions" menu. **You'll know it worked when:** A new, structured summary or overview appears in your Notebook, highlighting the main points and themes from all your uploaded sources.

Common mistakes

- **Expecting general knowledge answers:** NotebookLM *only* answers from your uploaded sources. If you ask a question not covered in your documents, it won't be able to help, and might even tell you it can't find the information. **Fix:** Always ensure your question can be answered by the content you've provided.
- **Uploading unsupported file types:** While NotebookLM supports common formats like PDFs and Google Docs, it can't read every type of file (e.g., image files, spreadsheets, or proprietary formats). **Fix:** Convert your documents to a supported format like PDF or plain text before uploading.
- **Asking overly broad or vague questions:** A very general question might lead to a generic or incomplete answer, even with relevant sources. **Fix:** Be specific with your prompts. If you want details on a particular section, mention it. If you want a specific type of information, ask for it directly (e.g., "List the pros and cons of X").

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** If you're planning a trip, you could upload travel guides and articles into a Notebook and ask it to highlight the best restaurants or activities in your destination, saving hours of reading.
- **For your business or work:** You can drop in client reports, internal policies, or research papers and quickly get summaries, compare different sections, or pull out specific data points for presentations, making your research much faster and more accurate.
- **If you're just getting started:** Try uploading a favorite recipe or a hobby-related article. Then, ask NotebookLM simple questions like "What are the main ingredients?" or "What's the first step?" to get a feel for how it extracts information.

Try it now

Open Google NotebookLM, create a new Notebook, and upload two or three of your own PDF documents, like a household bill, a product manual, or an article you've saved. Then, ask it: "What are the key points in these documents?"

Summarize Any Long Document or Article with AI

6 steps · Read online

Tired of scrolling through a 20-page policy, a lengthy news article, or a long email thread? This guide will show you how to use a free AI tool to quickly get a short, reliable summary. In just a few minutes, you'll be able to cut through the noise and focus only on what truly matters.

Before you start

- **A device with internet access:** A computer, tablet, or smartphone is perfect.
- **A free AI chat tool:** We'll use general instructions that work for popular options like ChatGPT (find it at `chat.openai.com`) or Gemini (at `gemini.google.com`). You'll need to create a free account and log in.
- **A document or article to shorten:** This could be a webpage, a PDF where you can select text, an email thread, or any plain text.
- **Rough total time:** About 6 minutes to follow all the steps.

Step 1 — Copy your document text

First, open the document or article that you want the AI to summarize. Once it's open, you need to select all the relevant text. On a computer, you can often do this by clicking your mouse at the start of the text and dragging to the end, or by using a keyboard shortcut like `Ctrl+A` (Windows) or `Cmd+A` (Mac) to select everything. With the text highlighted, press `Ctrl+C` (Windows) or `Cmd+C` (Mac) to copy it to your **clipboard**. The clipboard is a temporary storage area on your device, like a hidden notepad, where copied items wait to be pasted.

You'll know it worked when the text is highlighted (often in blue or gray), and you've used the copy command. Although nothing visibly changes on your screen after copying, the text is now safely on your clipboard, ready for the next step. If you can't select text, try opening the document in a different program (e.g., a web browser for PDFs) or look for a "Select All" option within the application's menu.

Example: Open a long email thread. Press `Ctrl+A` (Windows) or `Cmd+A` (Mac) to select the entire email body, then press `Ctrl+C` (Windows) or `Cmd+C` (Mac).

Step 2 — Open your AI chat tool

Next, open your preferred free AI chat tool in your web browser or dedicated app. For instance, you might type `chat.openai.com` into your browser's address bar for ChatGPT, or `gemini.google.com` for Gemini. If you're using a phone or tablet, simply launch the app. If you're prompted, make sure you're logged into your free account.

You'll typically see the AI tool's main chat interface, which usually features a large, empty text box at the bottom of the screen. This is where you'll type your messages to the AI. The tool is now waiting for your instructions. If your screen looks different, or you see old conversations, look for a "New Chat" button, a plus sign icon (`+`), or a similar option to start a fresh, blank conversation.

Example: Open your web browser and navigate to `gemini.google.com`. Log in to your account if prompted, then ensure you have a blank conversation ready.

You'll know it worked when you see an empty chat box, ready for you to type your first message, usually labeled "Message [AI name]..." or "Type your prompt here...".

Step 3 — Craft your summary request (Prompt)

Now, in the AI's chat box, you'll type your instruction for the summary. This instruction is called a **prompt** – it's like giving a clear job description to the AI. Be specific about the desired length, format (e.g., bullet points), and tone for your summary. A good prompt helps the AI understand exactly what you need.

You'll see the words you type appearing in the chat box. At this stage, the AI is just receiving your input, and you haven't sent anything yet. If the chat box shows pre-written suggestions, simply ignore them and type your own request. Being clear upfront saves time later.

Example: Type this into the chat box (do not press Enter or Send yet):

> "Please summarize the following document in three concise bullet points. Keep the language neutral and factual, avoiding any personal opinions or interpretations."

You'll know it worked when your complete summary request is typed into the box, clearly visible, but you haven't sent it to the AI yet.

Step 4 — Paste your text and send

After typing your summary request, move your cursor to the end of your prompt, then immediately paste the long document text that you copied in Step 1. You can do this by pressing `Ctrl+V` (Windows) or `Cmd+V` (Mac). The pasted text will appear right after your instruction in the same chat

box. Once both your prompt and the entire document text are in the box, press Enter or click the "Send" button (often a paper plane icon) to send everything to the AI.

You'll see your prompt and the long document text appear in the chat history. After a moment, the AI will start generating its response. This processing is called **inference**, which is when the AI "thinks" about your request and creates an output. If your document is extremely long (e.g., hundreds of pages), the AI might tell you it's too much text for its **context window**. The context window is like the AI's short-term memory – the amount of information it can "remember" and process at once. If this happens, you might need to break your document into smaller chunks and summarize them separately, or consider a paid plan, as some free versions may have usage restrictions.

Example:

> "Please summarize the following document in three concise bullet points. Keep the language neutral and factual, avoiding any personal opinions or interpretations.
>
> [Now, paste your copied document text here, directly after the prompt.]"

You'll know it worked when you see your message disappear into the chat history, and the AI begins to type out its summary, usually appearing as new text below your input.

Step 5 — Check and refine the summary

Once the AI has generated its summary, carefully read through the bullet points it provided. Compare them against the original document to ensure they are accurate, don't miss any crucial details, and match the tone you requested. Sometimes, AI can "hallucinate" – meaning it confidently makes up information that isn't present in the original text, or misinterprets something. If anything feels off, needs clarification, or isn't quite what you wanted, simply type a follow-up question or instruction in the chat box.

You'll see the AI's initial summary in the chat. When you ask a follow-up question, your new prompt will appear, and then the AI will try to adjust its response based on your feedback. If the AI completely misunderstands or gives a poor response, you might need to try rephrasing your initial prompt more clearly or start a new chat conversation altogether.

Example:

> "The third bullet point mentions 'Section 5'. Please confirm the exact wording of Section 5 from the original text and update that bullet point to be more precise. Also, can you ensure the overall tone is strictly professional?"

You'll know it worked when the AI responds with an updated summary that addresses your feedback, making it more accurate and aligned with your specific needs.

Step 6 — Finalise and use your summary

Once you are completely happy with the AI's summary, it's time to make it your own. You can copy the final bullet points from the chat interface to your clipboard. Most AI tools allow you to highlight the text with your mouse (click and drag) and then use the copy command (`Ctrl+C` or `Cmd+C`). Some tools may also have a specific "Copy" button or icon next to the AI's response to make this easier.

You'll see the polished, accurate summary on your screen. After copying, the text is on your clipboard, ready to be pasted into another application, like an email, a report, or your personal notes. If there isn't an obvious "copy" button, simply highlight the AI's text and use your device's standard copy function.

Example: Paste the finalised bullet points into a new email, a team chat application like Microsoft Teams, or a note-taking app on your phone to share or save.

You'll know it worked when the summary text is successfully copied (you can test this by pasting it into a simple text editor like Notepad or Notes) and you can then paste it into your desired application.

Common mistakes

- **Too vague a request:** Asking for "a summary" without specifying length or format can result in a lengthy, unstructured response. **The fix:** Always be specific. Say "in three bullet points," "one short paragraph," or "a summary suitable for an executive" in your prompt.
- **AI "hallucinations" or opinions:** AI tools can sometimes confidently present incorrect information or add their own interpretations that aren't in the original text. **The fix:** Always include phrases like "keep the language neutral and factual; do not add your own opinions" in your initial prompt, and critically review the summary against the original document. Don't be afraid to ask for corrections.
- **Text too long for the AI:** Trying to summarize extremely long documents (e.g., an entire book or a very dense legal document) might hit the AI's **context window** limits. **The fix:** Modern AI tools have much larger context windows than before, but extremely long documents may still require breaking them into smaller sections, or using a paid plan if available.

What this means for you

- **In everyday life:** The next time you receive a long work email, a detailed news article, a community newsletter, or even a lengthy recipe blog post, you can quickly get the main points without reading every single word. This saves you valuable time and helps you stay informed efficiently.
- **For your business or work:** Condense lengthy reports, meeting minutes, customer feedback surveys, or policy documents into concise, actionable bullet points. This can help you prepare for presentations faster, communicate key information efficiently to colleagues, or quickly grasp the core of complex documents. Remember, while AI is incredibly helpful, it cannot provide legal or medical advice, and human review is crucial for critical documents.
- **If you're just getting started:** Pick one long email thread you've received today, or a lengthy article you saved to read later. It's an easy first step that will quickly show you the power of AI summaries and build your confidence in using these tools.

Try it now

Open any long email thread you've received in the last week